3rd - 8th

ILLUMINATE LASD

CONNECTING CURIOSITY, CREATIVITY, AND AGENCY

Student Tools for Planning an Inquiry Overview

Sign up to participate by January 16th at https://tinyurl.com/illuminateLASD

3rd - 8th Grade Student Tools for Planning an Inquiry Overview

There is no single “right” way to move through an inquiry. The Student Tools for Planning an Inquiry is just one way you might begin exploring your inquiry. At the Illuminate event, you will need to showcase 3 important areas: *What did you investigate and why? What did you learn? How did you learn it?*

PHASE 1: WHAT ARE YOU INVESTIGATING AND WHY?

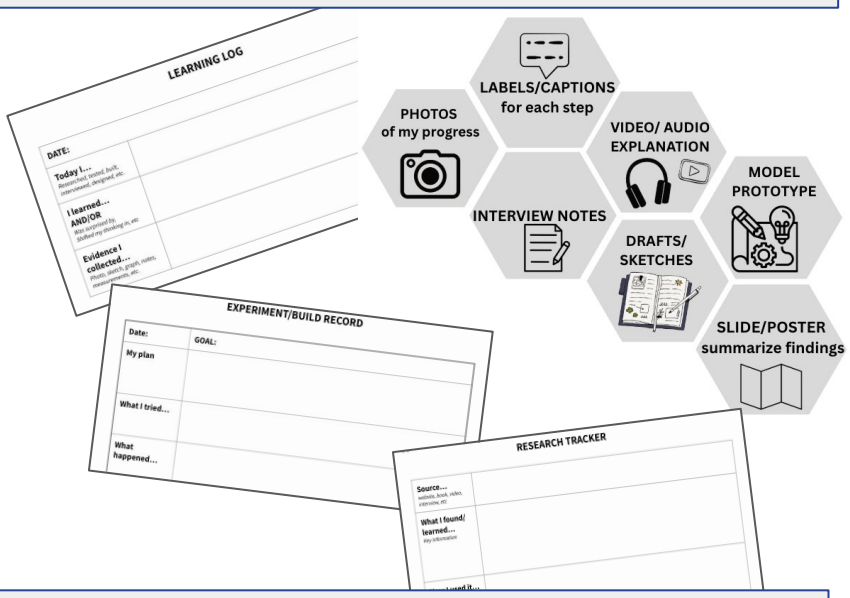
STEP 1: Determine a topic for investigation
What am I curious about?

STEP 2: Check if investigation is worthwhile
Is this a strong topic?

STEP 3: Writing an inquiry question
What is my inquiry?

PHASE 2: WHAT DID I LEARN?

Begin investigating and record your learning. Capturing your learning is less about listing facts and more about noticing your growth as a thinker, researcher, and a learner. Slow down, look back, and make the invisible… visible! Your job is to track the evolution of your wondering. Choose the template that is right for you and your inquiry, or build your own to record your learning!



PHASE 3: HOW DID I LEARN IT?

Reflect on your learning. There is a menu of reflection stems and templates to support you with being able to describe not only your product of learning (what you made or did) but also the process of learning (how you did it).

PHASE 4: EXHIBITION OF LEARNING - March 27th!

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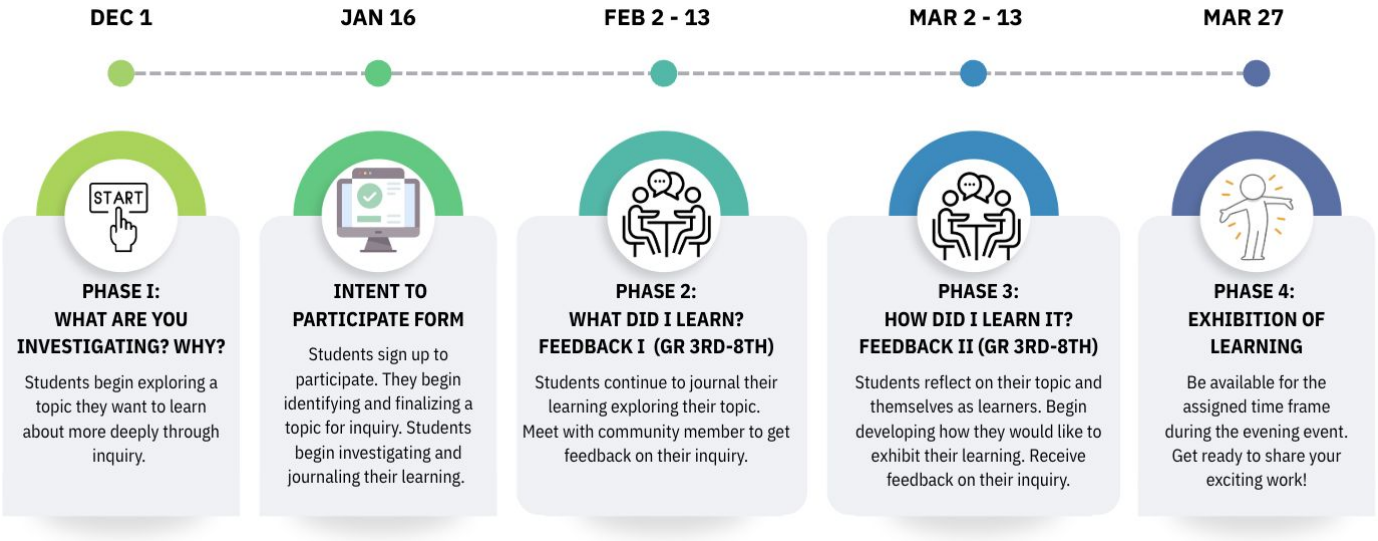
3rd - 8th GRADE TIMELINE

Utilize the following checklist to support you through your inquiry.

DATES	TASK
DEC 1 - JAN 16 *PHASE 1*	❏ Print any resources I need from *Student Tools for Planning an Inquiry* for project ❏ Finalize **inquiry question** ❏ Complete *Intent to Participate Form* online https://tinyurl.com/illuminateLASD
JAN 17 - FEB 2 *PHASE 2*	❏ Begin **investigating** about your topic. ❏ Choose the template that is right for you and your inquiry, or build your own to record your learning. From your notes to graphs, drawings, or anything else you are working on, have a place to **record** what your learning. ❏ Identify what you are **discovering** and now **thinking** about your inquiry. ❏ For 3rd- 8th grade students - Feedback I Window ❏ Feb 2 -13: Be ready to share… a) Final inquiry question b) Plan for how you plan to learn about your inquiry c) Beginning learnings about your inquiry
FEB 3 - MAR 2 *PHASE 3* *PHASE 4*	❏ Continue to capture your learning. Your job is to track the evolution of your wondering. ❏ For 3rd- 8th grade students - Feedback II Window ❏ Mar 2 -13: Be ready to share: a) What are you learning about your inquiry? b) How are you growing as a thinker, researcher, and learner? c) What are some ideas on how you will share with others your learning?
MAR 26 or 27 **Event Date! March 27th**	❏ Project materials due! Drop off either on March 26th at your school site or March 27th at Blach. ❏ On March 27th, plan to be at Blach by 3:30PM to set up the rest of your project.



VISIT FOR INQUIRY RESOURCES AND EVENT DETAILS: https://tinyurl.com/illuminateLASD

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3rd - 8th Grade Student Tools for Planning an Inquiry

PHASE 1: WHAT ARE YOU INVESTIGATING AND WHY?

STEP 1: Determine a topic for investigation

What am I curious about?
Use the ideas below as a starting point to determine a topic.

I'm curious about…

- ❑ How something works
- ❑ How something is made
- ❑ Why something happens
- ❑ How to get better at something
- ❑ How to help someone or something
- ❑ How things have changed over time
- ❑ Something in nature / science
- ❑ Something about a hobby
- ❑ Something about my community
- ❑ Something I want to build or design
- ❑ Something I want to compare

My ideas:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____
6. _____

Pick ONE idea that feels exciting, important, or useful to you.

_____

_____

STEP 2: Check if investigation is worthwhile

Is this a strong topic?
As you begin narrowing down what you want to explore, think about some questions that will help you reflect if it will be a meaningful inquiry for you.

- ❑ I care about it or want to learn more.
- ❑ I can find information or test something out.
- ❑ I can show what I learn (a model, writing, charts, photos, an experiment, etc).
- ❑ It's safe and doable at home.
- ❑ I can explain *why* it matters to me.

Can you check at least 3 boxes? If not, go back and think about how you can adjust your topic for investigation.

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STEP 3: Writing an inquiry question

What is my inquiry?

Pick an inquiry question stem and finish the question.

- ❑ What can we do to____?
- ❑ How does _____ work?
- ❑ Why does _____ happen?
- ❑ What is the best way to _____?
- ❑ How has _____changed over time?
- ❑ What factors affect _____?
- ❑ What would happen if _____?
- ❑ How do people use _____?
- ❑ What are the differences between _____ and _____?
- ❑ How can I design/build/create a better _____?
- ❑ How can I help _____?

My inquiry question (1st attempt)

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

My inquiry question (2nd attempt)

_____

_____

My inquiry question (3rd attempt)

_____

_____

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PHASE 2: WHAT DID I LEARN?

How do I capture my learning and show my growth as a learner?

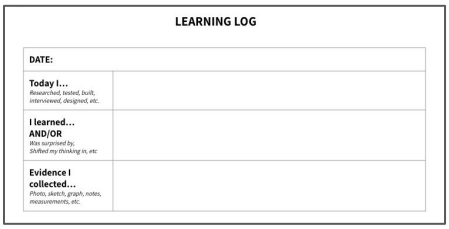
In this part of your inquiry, you begin exploring your ideas more deeply. You start by thinking about what you already know and why this inquiry matters to you. Then you begin to investigate. This might include talking to people who know more than you, testing things through experiments or hands-on tests, or perhaps reading/watching/listening to helpful sources.

You will start to sort and organize the information you are finding out. This could look like grouping ideas, noticing patterns or themes, creating diagrams, sketching, writing, discussing, or calculating. As you make sense of your learning, you may answer some of your original questions—and discover brand-new ones. Your inquiry may go deeper, wider, or even take you back to the beginning again. That's part of the journey.

As you learn, your job is to capture your thinking and not just the facts. Pay attention to how your ideas are changing and how you are growing as a thinker, researcher, and learner. You can choose the template that is right for you and your inquiry, or build your own to record your learning!

TEMPLATE 1: Learning Log

Each time you work on your inquiry, record what you did, what you learned, and the evidence you collected.



LEARNING LOG

DATE:	
Today I... *Researched, tested, built, interviewed, designed, etc.*	
I learned... AND/OR *Was surprised by, Shifted my thinking in, etc*	
Evidence I collected... *Photo, sketch, graph, notes, measurements, etc.*	

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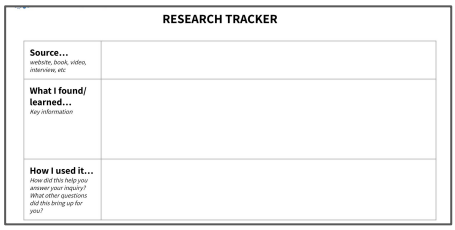
TEMPLATE 2: Research Tracker

Use this tracker to keep track of your research on a topic.



RESEARCH TRACKER

Source... *website, book, video, interview, etc*	
What I found/ learned... *Key information*	
How I used it... *How did this help you answer your inquiry? What other questions did this bring up for you?*	

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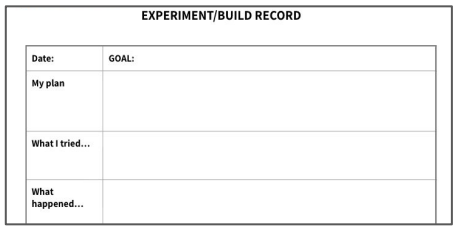
TEMPLATE 3: Experiment/ Build Record

Use this to record work you are doing as you build something or conduct an experiment.



EXPERIMENT/BUILD RECORD

Date:	GOAL:
My plan	
What I tried...	
What happened...	

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OTHER EVIDENCE OF LEARNING YOU CAN THINK ABOUT INCLUDING

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NAME:_____

LEARNING LOG

DATE:	
Today I… *Researched, tested, built, interviewed, designed, etc.*	
I learned… **AND/OR** *Was surprised by,* *Shifted my thinking in, etc*	
Evidence I collected… *Photo, sketch, graph, notes, measurements, etc.*	

DATE:	
Today I… *Researched, tested, built, interviewed, designed, etc.*	
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CONNECTING CURIOSITY, CREATIVITY, AND AGENCY

NAME:_____

RESEARCH TRACKER

Source… *website, book, video, interview, etc*	
What I found/ learned… *Key information*	
How I used it… *How did this help you answer your inquiry? What other questions did this bring up for you?*	

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CONNECTING CURIOSITY, CREATIVITY, AND AGENCY

NAME:_____

EXPERIMENT/BUILD RECORD

Date:	**GOAL:**
My plan	
What I tried…	
What happened…	
Changes I made or next steps I plan to make…	

Date:	**GOAL:**
My plan	
What I tried…	
What happened…	
Changes I made or next steps I plan to make…	

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3rd - 8th Grade Student Tools for Planning an Inquiry

PHASE 3: HOW DID I LEARN IT?

Reflect on your learning. Choose from a menu of reflection tools to support you in describing not only your product of learning (what you made or did) but also the process of learning (how you did it).

Sentence Starters

I can…	I was surprised when/by…	This will be useful when…	This got me thinking more about…	Now I feel confident about…
Now I need…	I needed…	I need to think more about…	I made connections to…	Something I struggled with was…

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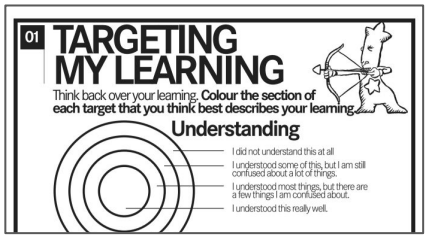
Targeting My Learning



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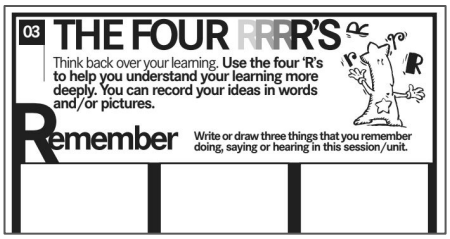
The Four RRRR's



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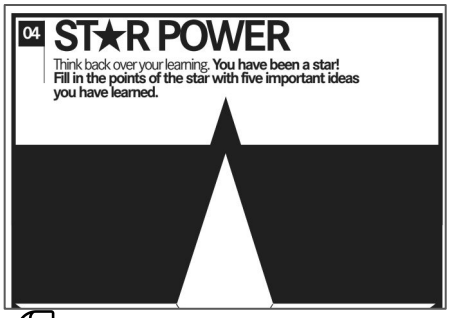
Star Power



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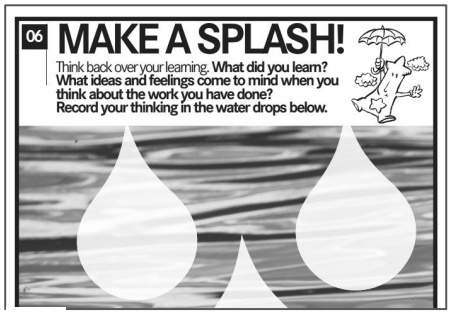
Thinking Outside the Square



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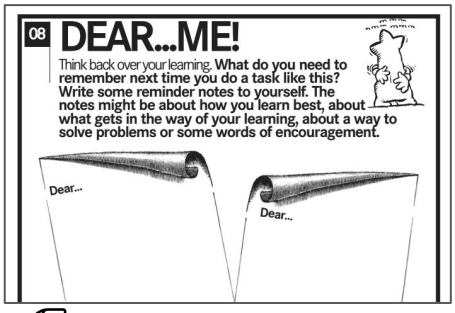
The Bridge



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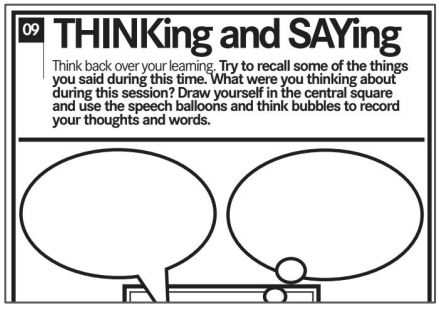
THINKing and SAYing



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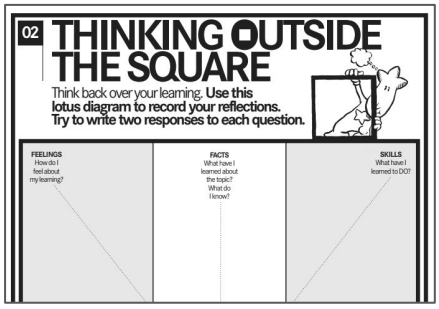
Make a Splash!



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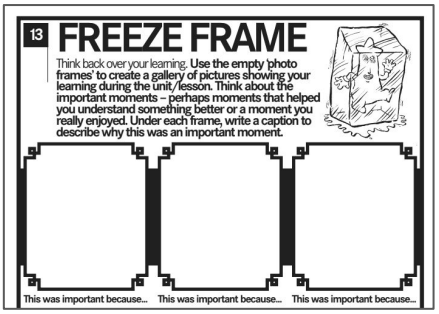
Freeze Frame



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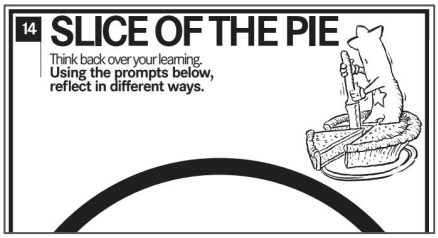
Slice of the Pie



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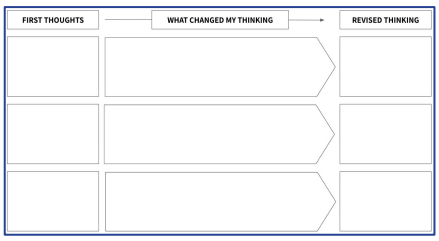
The Bridge



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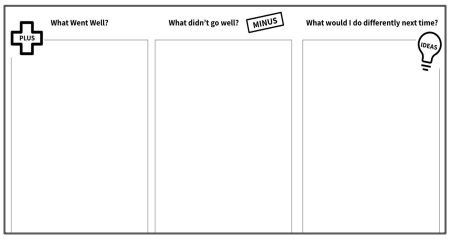
PMI (Plus, Minus, Idea)



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PHASE 4: EXHIBITION OF LEARNING

How do I want to share with others what I have learned?

You've pursued an important question—now it's time to share your discoveries with others. This is your opportunity to **showcase your growth**, **celebrate your achievements**, and **reflect on your learning journey**.

As you move deeper into your inquiry, you might pause and ask: **So what? Now what?** What have you come to understand, and how might you share these understandings with others? Think about the community you want to reach. What form of expression will connect with them? There are so many possibilities—films or animations, artworks, TED-style talks, websites, podcasts, books, teaching sessions, pamphlets, infographics, blogs, songs, dances, models, or interactive experiences. Choose a form that feels authentic to you and meaningful for your audience.

For the Exhibition of Learning, remember that we are just as interested in your *process* as we are in your product. Your final artifact is important, but the story of how you got there (photos, sketches, notes, recordings, journals, false starts and breakthroughs) helps others understand the richness of your learning journey. **The focus is sharing not only *what* you discovered or made, but *how* you learned.**

Your inquiry belongs to you. How you choose to share it has the power to influence, connect, and inspire.

ILLUMINATE EVENT DETAILS — MARCH 27, 2026

To prepare for your presentation, have all of your artifacts ready and organized! You will be assigned a window of time for your Exhibition of Learning. This is an interactive experience. Be ready to answer audience's questions about your project. Be confident, positive, and clear in your communication! You've got this!

3:30PM - 4:00PM	Students may come and finish setting up their areas.
4:00PM - 7:00PM	• Exhibition of Learning • Keynote Speaker • Food Trucks • Activities for the family - Interactive Installations
7:30PM	Projects may be taken home after 7:30PM.

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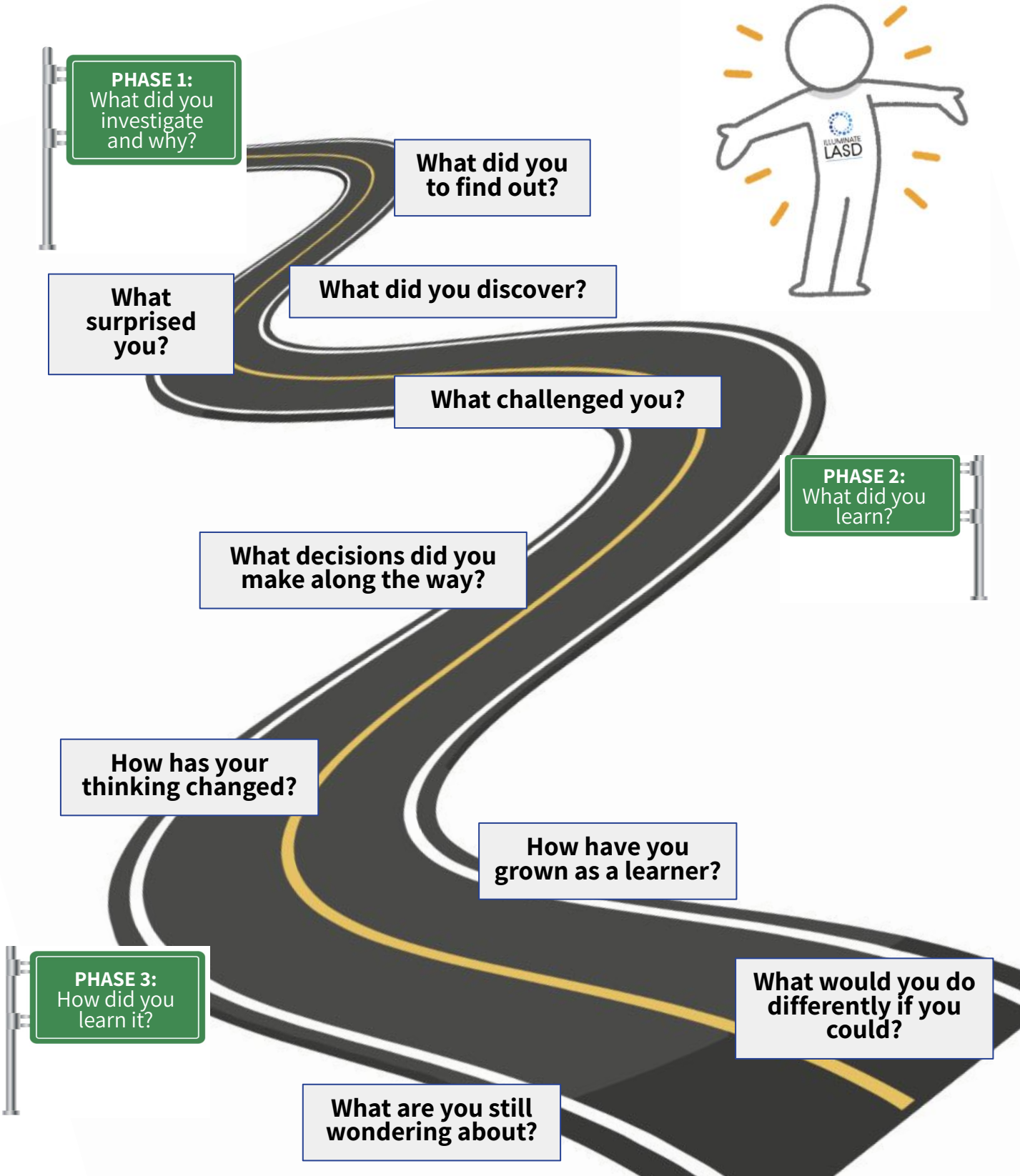
My Learning Story for the Exhibition of Learning

Think back to your first time starting your inquiry. From observation/reflection journals, photos, sketches, to the series of broken prototypes you've made and tested along your journey, your goal is to capture your learning story that showcase three important areas: *What did you investigate and why? What did you learn? How did you learn it?*